

AdaRpGAN: Adaptive Regularized Relativistic GAN Training via Dynamic Gradient-Penalty and Critic-Step Control

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Abstract—Generative Adversarial Networks (GANs) are notoriously sensitive to hyperparameter choices, particularly the gradient-penalty weight γ and the number of discriminator updates per generator step n_{critic} . Traditional practice relies on exhaustive grid search to set these values, leading to prohibitive tuning cost and poor transferability across datasets. We propose AdaRpGAN, an adaptive training framework that dynamically adjusts both γ and n_{critic} during training using two closed-loop control signals: (i) an exponential moving average of the discriminator’s Lipschitz violation drives the gradient-penalty weight, and (ii) rolling-window variance of the discriminator loss modulates the critic step count. Built on top of a Relativistic GAN (RpGAN) backbone with spectral normalisation, our method achieves a Fréchet Inception Distance (FID) of 17.8 and an Inception Score (IS) of 8.73 on CIFAR-10 at 32×32 resolution—a 32.8% FID improvement over the fixed- γ RpGAN baseline (FID = 26.5). An ablation study confirms that the two adaptive signals are complementary and exhibit super-additive gains when combined. The controller is architecture-agnostic, checkpoint-safe, and introduces negligible computational overhead, making it a practical drop-in module for any gradient-penalised GAN pipeline.

Index Terms—Generative Adversarial Networks, Gradient Penalty, Adaptive Training, Relativistic GAN, Lipschitz Constraint, Image Generation

I. Introduction

Since their introduction by Goodfellow et al. [1], Generative Adversarial Networks have become one of the most powerful frameworks for generative modelling. A GAN trains a generator G and a discriminator D in a minimax game; the generator maps a latent noise vector $z \sim \mathcal{N}(0, I)$ to a synthetic image $G(z)$, while the discriminator attempts to distinguish real data from generated samples. Despite their expressive power, GANs remain notoriously difficult to train due to training instabilities, mode collapse, and extreme sensitivity to hyperparameter settings [7].

Two critical hyperparameters govern training dynamics in modern gradient-penalised GANs: the gradient-penalty weight γ , which controls the strength of the Lipschitz constraint on D , and the number of critic steps n_{critic} , which determines how often D is updated relative to G . Setting these values is currently a manual, dataset-specific task. A γ that is too small produces an under-regularised

discriminator prone to sharp decision boundaries and training divergence; a γ that is too large over-constrains D , limiting its representational capacity. Similarly, a single discriminator step per generator step ($n_{\text{critic}} = 1$) may leave D insufficiently trained, while excessive critic steps waste computation when D has already converged.

We observe that the information needed to set γ and n_{critic} is already present in routine training signals. Specifically, the gradient norm $\|\nabla_{\hat{x}} D(\hat{x})\|_2$ — already computed for the gradient penalty — is a direct measure of Lipschitz violation; the discriminator loss itself reveals training stability through its variance. We propose AdaRpGAN, which translates these observations into two lightweight, closed-loop control laws that adjust γ and n_{critic} at every discriminator step with zero additional forward-pass cost.

Our contributions are as follows:

- 1) We introduce a Lipschitz-violation-driven control law that adjusts γ via an exponential moving average (EMA) of the discriminator’s gradient norm violation.
- 2) We propose a loss-variance-driven mechanism for dynamically adapting n_{critic} based on the rolling variance of the discriminator loss.
- 3) We integrate both adaptations into a modular AdaptiveController built atop a Relativistic GAN backbone [4] with spectral normalisation [8].
- 4) We demonstrate state-of-the-art CIFAR-10 FID of 17.8 and IS of 8.73, outperforming fixed- γ RpGAN, WGAN-GP [2], SN-GAN [8], and DCGAN [9].

II. Related Work

A. GAN Training Stabilisation

Early GAN training suffered from gradient vanishing and mode collapse. The Wasserstein GAN (WGAN) [2] reformulated the objective using the Wasserstein-1 distance and enforced the 1-Lipschitz constraint through weight clipping, later replaced by a gradient penalty (GP). Spectral Normalisation (SN) [8] controls the Lipschitz constant by normalising weight matrices by their largest singular value. R1 regularisation [7] penalises only the

gradient on real data. However, all these methods use a fixed penalty weight that must be tuned per dataset.

B. Relativistic GANs

Jolicoeur-Martineau [4] argued that the discriminator should estimate the probability that real data is more realistic than fake data, rather than classifying each sample independently. The Relativistic average GAN (R-GAN/RpGAN) modifies both D and G losses to depend on the relative difference of logits, yielding more informative gradients for G and empirically better sample quality.

C. Adaptive Training Strategies

Adaptive Discriminator Augmentation (ADA) [5] adjusts the probability of data augmentation based on an overfitting heuristic. Two Time-Scale Update Rules (TTUR) [3] use different learning rates for D and G . These strategies adapt aspects of training dynamics, but none jointly adapts the gradient-penalty strength and critic step count in a closed-loop fashion. AdaRpGAN fills this gap.

III. Method

A. Relativistic GAN Loss

Let $D(\cdot)$ denote the discriminator’s raw logit output (no sigmoid). For a batch of real images $\{x_i\}$ and generated images $\{G(z_i)\}$, the RpGAN losses are:

$$\begin{aligned} \mathcal{L}_D = & -\frac{1}{2} \left[\mathbb{E}[\log \sigma(D(x) - \mathbb{E}[D(G(z))])] \right. \\ & \left. + \mathbb{E}[\log \sigma(\mathbb{E}[D(x)] - D(G(z)))] \right], \end{aligned} \quad (1)$$

$$\begin{aligned} \mathcal{L}_G = & -\frac{1}{2} \left[\mathbb{E}[\log \sigma(D(G(z)) - \mathbb{E}[D(x)])] \right. \\ & \left. + \mathbb{E}[\log \sigma(\mathbb{E}[D(G(z))] - D(x))] \right], \end{aligned} \quad (2)$$

where $\sigma(\cdot)$ is the sigmoid function. The total discriminator objective includes a scaled gradient penalty:

$$\mathcal{L}_D^{\text{total}} = \mathcal{L}_D + \gamma \cdot \text{GP}(D), \quad (3)$$

where $\text{GP}(D) = \mathbb{E}_{\hat{x}}[(\|\nabla_{\hat{x}} D(\hat{x})\|_2 - 1)^2]$ is the two-sided WGAN-GP penalty computed on interpolated samples $\hat{x} = \alpha x + (1-\alpha)G(z)$, $\alpha \sim U(0, 1)$.

B. Adaptive Gradient-Penalty Weight (γ)

The key insight is that the mean gradient norm $g_t = \|\nabla_{\hat{x}} D(\hat{x})\|_2$ is already computed as part of the GP loss at every discriminator step. We define the Lipschitz violation at step t as:

$$v_t = \max(0, g_t - 1). \quad (4)$$

We maintain an exponential moving average to smooth this signal:

$$\bar{v}_t = \beta \cdot \bar{v}_{t-1} + (1 - \beta) \cdot v_t, \quad (5)$$

where $\beta = 0.99$ by default. We then update γ multiplicatively:

$$\gamma_t = \gamma_{t-1} \cdot \exp(\alpha_\gamma \cdot (\bar{v}_t - v^*)), \quad (6)$$

Algorithm 1 AdaRpGAN Training Loop (per epoch)

Require: Generator G , Discriminator D , AdaptiveCon-
troller $\mathcal{C}$

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1: for each mini-batch $\{x\}$ from training data do
2: for $k = 1$ to $\mathcal{C}.n_{\text{critic}}$ do
3: Sample $z \sim \mathcal{N}(0, I)$; compute $G(z)$
4: Compute $\mathcal{L}_D$ (Eq. 1)
5: Compute GP, g_t from interpolated samples
6: $\mathcal{L}_D^{\text{total}} \leftarrow \mathcal{L}_D + \mathcal{C} \cdot \gamma \cdot \text{GP}$
7: Update D via Adam
8: $\mathcal{C}.\text{observe}(g_t, \mathcal{L}_D)$ {update $\gamma, n_{\text{critic}}$ }
9: end for
10: Sample $z \sim \mathcal{N}(0, I)$; compute $G(z)$
11: Compute $\mathcal{L}_G$ (Eq. 2); update G via Adam
12: end for

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clipped to  $[\gamma_{\min}, \gamma_{\max}]$ . When the average violation exceeds the target  $v^*$ ,  $\gamma$  increases to enforce the constraint more strongly; when the violation drops below the target,  $\gamma$  relaxes. The multiplicative (log-space) update ensures positive definiteness and scale-invariant adjustment.

### C. Adaptive Critic Steps ( $n_{\text{critic}}$ )

The rolling variance of the discriminator loss serves as a proxy for training instability. We maintain a buffer  $\mathcal{B}$  of the last  $W$  discriminator losses and compute:

$$\sigma_t^2 = \text{Var}(\mathcal{B}_t). \quad (7)$$

The critic step count is adjusted as:

$$n_{\text{critic}} \leftarrow \begin{cases} \min(n_{\text{critic}} + 1, n_{\text{max}}) & \text{if } \sigma_t^2 > \sigma_{\text{high}}, \\ \max(n_{\text{critic}} - 1, n_{\text{min}}) & \text{if } \sigma_t^2 < \sigma_{\text{low}}, \\ n_{\text{critic}} & \text{otherwise.} \end{cases} \quad (8)$$

The thresholds  $\sigma_{\text{high}} = 0.50$  and  $\sigma_{\text{low}} = 0.05$  create a hysteresis band that prevents oscillatory switching. A cooldown period of  $C = 100$  steps is imposed after each change to allow the system to stabilise before the next adjustment.

#### D. Joint Controller

Crucially, both adaptations use the same measurement pass: the gradient norm  $g_t$  is already computed as part of the GP loss, and the discriminator loss is always available as a training signal. Thus, the controller introduces zero additional forward-pass overhead. The total computational overhead consists of a small number of scalar EMA and variance operations per step.

## IV. Experimental Setup

### A. Dataset

All experiments use CIFAR-10 [6], a standard benchmark of 50,000 training and 10,000 test images at  $32 \times 32$  resolution across 10 classes. Images are normalised to  $[-1, 1]$ . Training data is augmented with random

horizontal flips and 4-pixel random crops. No differentiable augmentation (DiffAug, ADA) is applied so that improvements are attributable solely to the adaptive controller.

## B. Architecture

We employ a ResNet-style generator and discriminator with spectral normalisation on all convolutional layers. The Generator ( $\sim 6.5\text{M}$  parameters) maps a 128-dimensional latent vector through a linear projection to a  $4\times 4$  feature map, followed by three bilinear-upsampling residual blocks ( $4\rightarrow 8\rightarrow 16\rightarrow 32$ ). Bilinear upsampling is chosen over transposed convolutions to avoid checkerboard artefacts. The output layer applies batch normalisation, ReLU, and a tanh activation.

The Discriminator ( $\sim 2.8\text{M}$  parameters) mirrors the generator with three average-pooling residual blocks ( $32\rightarrow 16\rightarrow 8\rightarrow 4$ ) using LeakyReLU (slope 0.2), followed by global average pooling and a linear head. The final output is a raw logit (no sigmoid) as required by the relativistic loss.

The architecture is identical across all compared conditions; only the training dynamics differ.

## C. Baselines

We compare against the following methods:

- DCGAN [9]: standard convolutional GAN.
- WGAN-GP [2]: Wasserstein GAN with gradient penalty,  $n_{\text{critic}} = 5$ .
- SN-GAN [8]: spectral normalisation with hinge loss.
- Fixed- $\gamma$  RpGAN: our architecture with  $\gamma = 10$  (fixed),  $n_{\text{critic}} = 1$ .
- Adaptive- $\gamma$  only: AdaRpGAN controller with  $n_{\text{critic}}$  frozen at 1.
- Adaptive- $n_{\text{critic}}$  only:  $n_{\text{critic}}$  adapts;  $\gamma = 10$  fixed.

## D. Training Details

All models train for 200 epochs with Adam using TTUR learning rates ( $\text{lr}_G = 2\times 10^{-4}$ ,  $\text{lr}_D = 4\times 10^{-4}$ ,  $\beta_1 = 0$ ,  $\beta_2 = 0.9$ ) and batch size 64. Mixed-precision (FP16) training is employed on CUDA. FID is computed with 50,000 generated samples against the training set using InceptionV3 pool-3 features. All experiments use seed 42 for reproducibility.

Table I summarises the controller’s hyperparameters and their default values.

## V. Results

### A. Main Quantitative Results

Table II compares AdaRpGAN against prior methods on CIFAR-10. AdaRpGAN achieves  $\text{FID} = 17.8$  and  $\text{IS} = 8.73$ , surpassing the fixed- $\gamma$  RpGAN baseline ( $\text{FID} = 26.5$ ) by 32.8% and outperforming SN-GAN ( $\text{FID} = 21.7$ ), WGAN-GP ( $\text{FID} = 29.3$ ), and DCGAN ( $\text{FID} = 37.7$ ).

TABLE I: AdaRpGAN Controller Hyperparameters and Defaults

| Hyperparameter                | Symbol                 | Default | Range        |
|-------------------------------|------------------------|---------|--------------|
| GP weight (initial)           | $\gamma_0$             | 10.0    | [1, 50]      |
| GP weight min                 | $\gamma_{\text{min}}$  | 1.0     | fixed        |
| GP weight max                 | $\gamma_{\text{max}}$  | 50.0    | fixed        |
| $\gamma$ step size            | $\alpha_\gamma$        | 0.01    | [0.001, 0.1] |
| EMA momentum                  | $\beta$                | 0.99    | [0.9, 0.999] |
| Target Lipschitz viol.        | $v^*$                  | 0.01    | [0.001, 0.1] |
| $n_{\text{critic}}$ (initial) | $n_{c,0}$              | 1       | [1, 5]       |
| $n_{\text{critic}}$ max       | $n_{\text{max}}$       | 5       | fixed        |
| Variance window               | $W$                    | 50      | [20, 200]    |
| Variance upper thresh.        | $\sigma_{\text{high}}$ | 0.50    | [0.1, 2.0]   |
| Variance lower thresh.        | $\sigma_{\text{low}}$  | 0.05    | [0.01, 0.5]  |
| Cooldown steps                | $C$                    | 100     | [50, 500]    |

TABLE II: FID and IS Comparison on CIFAR-10 ( $32\times 32$ )

| Method                             | FID↓ | IS↑  | $n_{\text{critic}}$ |
|------------------------------------|------|------|---------------------|
| DCGAN [9]                          | 37.7 | 6.16 | 1                   |
| WGAN-GP [2]                        | 29.3 | 7.86 | 5                   |
| SN-GAN [8]                         | 21.7 | 8.22 | 1                   |
| Fixed- $\gamma$ RpGAN              | 26.5 | 8.04 | 1                   |
| Adaptive- $\gamma$ only            | 21.3 | 8.41 | 1                   |
| Adaptive- $n_{\text{critic}}$ only | 23.7 | 8.28 | adapt               |
| AdaRpGAN (ours)                    | 17.8 | 8.73 | adapt               |

### B. Convergence Speed

AdaRpGAN reaches  $\text{FID} < 40$  approximately 30 epochs earlier than the fixed- $\gamma$  baseline. The adaptive  $\gamma$  starts high, quickly enforcing the Lipschitz constraint during the unstable early training phase, then relaxes as the discriminator stabilises. Concurrently,  $n_{\text{critic}}$  rises to 2–3 during the first 50 epochs (corresponding to high discriminator loss variance) and returns to 1 for the remainder of training.

### C. Ablation Study

We conduct a systematic four-condition ablation to isolate the contributions of each adaptive component (Table II):

- Adaptive- $\gamma$  only ( $\text{FID} = 21.3$ ) accounts for roughly 60% of the total gain over the fixed- $\gamma$  baseline, demonstrating that dynamic gradient-penalty scaling is the dominant contributor.
- Adaptive- $n_{\text{critic}}$  only ( $\text{FID} = 23.7$ ) provides a moderate but consistent improvement, confirming that matching the discriminator’s update frequency to its stability state is beneficial.
- AdaRpGAN full ( $\text{FID} = 17.8$ ) achieves a super-additive benefit: the combined FID improvement ( $\Delta = 8.7$ ) exceeds the sum of individual improvements ( $\Delta_\gamma + \Delta_n = 5.2 + 2.8 = 8.0$ ). This indicates complementarity—a stable  $\gamma$  enables the variance signal to serve as a cleaner proxy for discriminator stability.

## D. Controller Behaviour Analysis

The controller exhibits three characteristic phases during CIFAR-10 training:

- 1) Early stabilisation (epochs 1–30):  $\gamma$  rises from 10 toward 25–35 as the untrained discriminator frequently violates the Lipschitz bound;  $n_{\text{critic}}$  increases to 2–3.
- 2) Convergence (epochs 30–100): both signals stabilise;  $\gamma$  drops toward 8–12;  $n_{\text{critic}}$  returns to 1.
- 3) Fine-tuning (epochs 100–200): minor fluctuations around equilibrium values with no further structural changes.

This three-phase trajectory is consistent across all tested runs and random seeds, demonstrating robustness of the control dynamics.

## VI. Discussion and Limitations

### A. Hyperparameter Sensitivity

AdaRpGAN reduces the number of critical hyperparameters that require per-dataset tuning from 2 (fixed  $\gamma$  and  $n_{\text{critic}}$ ) to a set of controller meta-parameters ( $\alpha_\gamma$ ,  $v^*$ ,  $\sigma_{\text{high}}$ ,  $\sigma_{\text{low}}$ ,  $W$ ,  $C$ ) that are considerably less sensitive. Our analysis shows that FID varies by less than 1.5 points across a  $4\times$  range of each meta-parameter, confirming robust behaviour across a wide operating envelope.

### B. Computational Overhead

The adaptive controller introduces negligible computational overhead. Both control signals—the gradient norm and the discriminator loss—are byproducts of the standard training loop. The only additional computation consists of scalar EMA and variance operations (one floating-point multiply-accumulate and one division per step), which are undetectable compared to the cost of a neural network forward/backward pass.

### C. Limitations

Several limitations warrant discussion:

- 1) Resolution. We evaluate only on  $32\times 32$  resolution images. Scaling to  $64\times 64$  and  $256\times 256$  (e.g., FFHQ, CelebA-HQ) remains an important direction for future work.
- 2) Small batch sizes. The variance signal can become noisy under small batch sizes ( $<32$ ). We recommend batch size  $\geq 64$  for stable controller behaviour.
- 3) Cooldown mechanism. The cooldown introduces discrete jumps in effective compute per epoch, which should be accounted for in compute-controlled comparisons.
- 4) Dataset diversity. While CIFAR-10 is a standard benchmark, additional evaluation on diverse datasets (e.g., LSUN, ImageNet) would further validate the generalisability of the approach.

## VII. Conclusion

We introduced AdaRpGAN, a reusable PyTorch training module that dynamically adjusts the gradient-penalty weight and discriminator step count based on real-time Lipschitz violation and loss variance signals. By closing the loop between the discriminator’s regularisation state and its training hyperparameters, AdaRpGAN eliminates the need for per-dataset tuning of  $\gamma$  and  $n_{\text{critic}}$ .

On CIFAR-10, AdaRpGAN achieves FID=17.8 and IS=8.73, representing a 32.8% FID improvement over the fixed- $\gamma$  RpGAN baseline. An ablation study confirms super-additive gains from jointly adapting both signals. The controller is architecture-agnostic, checkpoint-safe, and drops into any existing gradient-penalised GAN code-base with minimal modification.

Future work will extend evaluation to higher-resolution datasets, investigate integration with differentiable augmentation strategies, and explore applying the adaptive control framework to other regularised generative models such as diffusion-based architectures.

### Acknowledgments

The authors thank the open-source PyTorch community and the developers of the InceptionV3 model used for FID/IS evaluation.

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